

tasks such as playing Genshin Impact or rendering high-quality videos.

As for GPU Benchmarks, the scores are decent but they pale in comparison to the iQOO 12. The same is confirmed in real-world gaming tests. The iQOO 12 can easily handle high graphics gaming with minimal frame drops, but the same cannot be said for the Pixel 8a, especially during prolonged gaming sessions.

SOFTWARE

The software experience on the Pixel 8a is one of its strongest points. Running stock Android 14, it provides a clean and intuitive user interface free of bloatware. Google's commitment to long-term updates ensures that users will receive the latest features and security patches for years to come. The phone runs on Android 14 out-of-the-box and promises seven years of software updates, which is a significant advantage for longevity.

AI-powered features like Magic Eraser, Best Take, Audio Magic Eraser, AI wallpapers, and Magic Editor enhance the overall usability of the device, making photo editing a fun and fruitful experience. The integration of AI into the user experience is seamless, and these features work effectively to improve daily tasks and enhance creativity.

CAMERAS

The Pixel 8a is equipped with a 64MP primary sensor and a 13MP ultra-wide sensor on the back, along with a 13MP front camera. The primary camera excels in capturing detailed photos with vibrant colors and good contrast. In bright light, the Pixel 8a excels with accurate colour reproduction and fine detail preservation, maintaining Google's reputation for strong camera software optimisation. The dynamic range is well-handled, ensuring that both highlights and shadows are captured effectively.

This makes the Pixel 8a particularly adept at landscape and outdoor photography, where lighting conditions can vary widely. Portrait mode on the Pixel



8a benefits from Google's advanced computational photography, producing pleasing bokeh effects and accurate subject isolation.

The ultra-wide sensor also performs well, maintaining consistency in color treatment across different shooting modes. While not as strong as the main sensor, it offers good performance with minimal distortion.

Low-light performance is impressive, with minimal noise and good detail retention. The AI-driven camera software helps in producing social media-ready images straight out of the camera. The auto-focus system is reliable and quick, further enhancing its usability in low-light conditions. Video recording supports 4K resolution and maintains stability, though the high contrast can sometimes appear unnatural.

The camera's real strength lies in its software features. Magic Eraser and other AI tools provide significant enhancements to photo editing, making it easy to remove unwanted objects and adjust images creatively.

BATTERY LIFE

The Pixel 8a houses a 4492mAh battery, a slight upgrade from the previous model. It comfortably lasts a full day with moderate to heavy use, even with features like always-on display and 120Hz refresh rate enabled.

However, the charging speed is a notable downside, as it only supports 18W wired charging and 7.5W wireless charging. This is quite slow compared to other devices in its price range, and

Google continues to omit the charger from the box.

VERDICT

Despite the steep price hike, the Google Pixel 8a stands out for its compact design, excellent camera capabilities, and clean Android experience, bolstered by long-term software support. Its AI-driven features enhance usability as well. It provides a Pixel 8-like experience at a lower cost. However, it does have drawbacks such as slow charging speeds and occasional heating issues, which could be significant for some users. Especially since the smartphone market is packed with options in the same price including the beloved iQOO 12 and OnePlus 12R. Additionally, the ₹9,000 price hike from its predecessors will most likely not go down well with the Indian audience. Overall, the Pixel 8a is a solid choice for Pixel enthusiasts, though it may not meet the needs of users seeking the fastest charging or top-tier performance.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Google Tensor G3 | GPU: Immortalis-G715s MC10 | RAM: 8 GB LPDDR5X | Storage: 128/256 GB UFS 3.1 | OS: Android 14 | Display: 6.1" OLED, 120 Hz, 1080 x 2400 pixels | Display protection: Gorilla Glass 3 | Cameras (rear): 64 MP + 13 MP | Front camera: 13 MP | Battery capacity: 4492 mAh | Charging: 18 W wired, 7.5 W wireless | Colours: Obsidian, Porcelain, Bay, Aloe | IP rating: IP67

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